

In WordPress, the Article Editor is straight-forward WYSIWYG. You can enter the title, use the Toolbar to format the text, select categories and tags, and publish your post!

In Drupal, the same process, though relatively more complex, can still be done with ease. You need to specify the title, tags and the text. Following that, you can set options for *Menus*, *URL Alias*, *Revision Logs*, *Author Metadata* and *Comments*. The same features are also available in WordPress, but are hidden by default. This is where WP wins—the great level of abstraction not only simplifies the CMS, but also makes it extremely usable. In Drupal, there is no (simple) way to hide the unnecessary fields in the Article Editor.

Coming to Joomla!—Code Mirror has been introduced in version 2.5, but it strictly caters to a specific genre of users who like to post their articles in HTML/code, rather than use WYSIWYG.

The default TinyMCE Article Editor has the same Toolbar as that of WP, but the layout and interface is confusing. You can set the categories, tags, author metadata, comment moderation values, etc. In terms of *Article Properties* and *Permissions*, you can set its parents/children, visibility settings, etc. Obviously, such features are not needed by everyone. Again, WP and Drupal do away with such bloated mechanisms. If you need to specify *Permissions/Properties*, you can do so by means of plug-ins/extensions in either WP or Drupal. Otherwise, more often than not, WordPress and Drupal do not bombard you with such relatively unused features.

The etceteras

Let us now come to the other major factors that determine the USP of a CMS.

Security: WordPress is notorious for being the least secure CMS. While this is definitely because it is the most popular CMS, and thus relatively easier to hack, it still cannot be denied that newer security loop-holes are discovered in WP way more often than in either Drupal or Joomla! Furthermore, WP plug-ins and themes too come with their share of hacks and exploits. Drupal, on the other hand, seems to be the most secure CMS of the three, with the least number of hacks and exploits, on an average (it was chosen by The White House for its website, after all).

Extensibility: In terms of freely available extensions and templates, all three CMSs come out evenly matched. However, it is in terms of commercial themes and extensions that WordPress wins the race. WP is supplemented by numerous commercial extensions' marketplaces, such as Theme Forest and WooThemes that specialise in WP extensions. Sadly, the commercial extensions for Drupal and Joomla! stand nowhere in comparison.

User base and support: All three CMSs are well documented and have their own forums. However, when it

comes to unofficial support, Joomla! and WordPress take the lead. Just search for 'wordpress tips' on Google, and you'll come across numerous blogs and websites dedicated to sharing their expertise on WP, and the same applies to Joomla! Sadly, Drupal doesn't really have much unofficial support beyond the main documentation. Speaking of the user base, all three CMSs have a loyal following, though WordPress does not have the same level of activity on its forums as the other two CMSs.

The verdict

WordPress is by far the most user friendly and popular CMS of the three. It can be used to run things way beyond blogs, and its popularity ensures that it has a monumental pile of plug-ins and themes (both good and bad) to its credit.

Drupal and Joomla!, on the other hand, are also in active development and have a dedicated developer community, but do not beat WP in terms of usability.

So, who wins?

If you are designing a website for a not-so-technical client, or are looking for a simple solution to create a website, WP should be your preferred choice. Using Drupal or Joomla! for a simple blog will be overkill. If security is a concern, Drupal or even Joomla! would be preferred. Along similar lines, if your website is of gigantic proportions (say, over 15,000 pages), Drupal can easily offer the robustness that you need.

On a personal note, I use WordPress for most of my websites, and Drupal and Joomla! for some others. While WP gets the task done easily and gives me the time to do better things, Joomla! doesn't. Drupal, on the other hand, has not given me any error message yet (and I do not suppose it will, any time soon). For my WP websites, I can pick any theme as and when I feel like; for Drupal, my best source is *drupalizing* (www.drupalizing.com/), and for Joomla!, coding the template myself will be better than searching for a worthy theme. **END** 

Suggested reading

- [1] 'How WordPress Took the CMS Crown from Drupal and Joomla!'—Smashing Magazine. wp.smashingmagazine.com/2011/11/29/wordpress-cms-crown-drupal-joomla/

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